Critical writing and using literature efficiently

COMP3000

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BE-BE-JN



Dr Jason Truscott

Library and Learning Services

Attendance register: only for this library session



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Support is everywhere!



www.plymouth.ac.uk/services/library-services

Library and Learning Services can help with developing academic skills in the following:

- writing and presenting
- developing thinking
- using literature critically
- managing projects
- articulating knowledge
- communicating ideas
- preparing for exams and assessment



The Writing Café

- Drop in (no booking!)
- **Writing Café**: 1st Floor of library (**Charles Seale-Hayne Library**)
- Typically, ‘Group study’ area next to the library cafe
- writing support 1-4 pm, Mon-Thurs (Semester / term time)
- In person OR Zoom

www.plymouth.ac.uk/learn







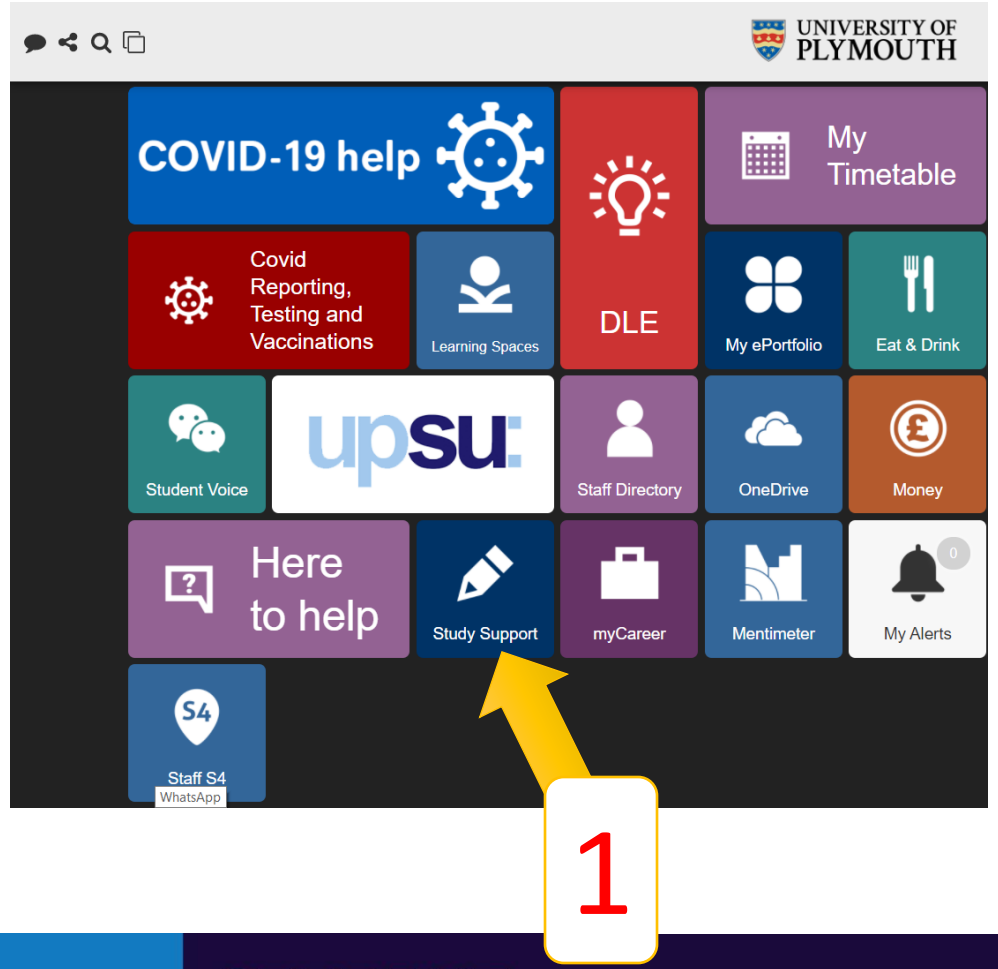
Royal Literary Fund Writing Fellow (writing tutorials)

- How to structure your writing
- How to make your writing clearer
- How to write a good introduction or conclusion
- Help with dissertations
- and anything else directly related to academic writing.
  - **Individuals only 45-50mins**

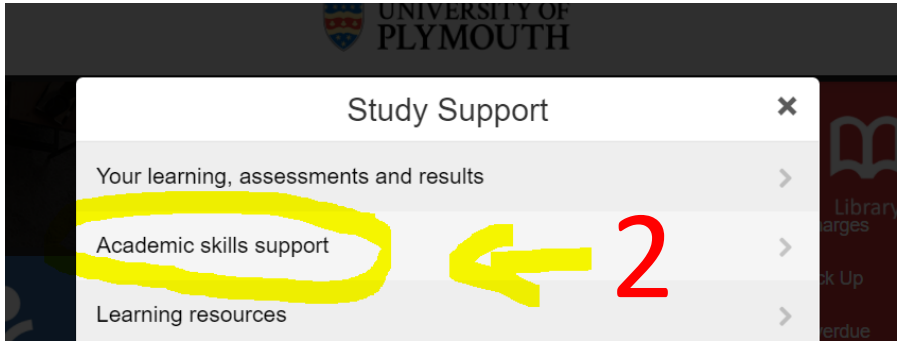
https://www.plymouth.ac.uk/student-life/services/student-services/learning-development/royal-literary-fund-writing-fellow



Where to find ALL the help and support



- plymouth.ac.uk (login via portal)
- Select study support (see 1)
- 'Academic Skills support' (see 2)



- **Choose options on next screen**

Today's session

1. What is the approach to academic writing
2. Deciding on the literature review topic
3. Search the literature
4. Being critical of the literature you find
5. Knowing what to keep or discard
6. Deciding the order of your ‘points’ of argument
7. Writing the review using critical thinking
8. Recommendations and close

Free-writing

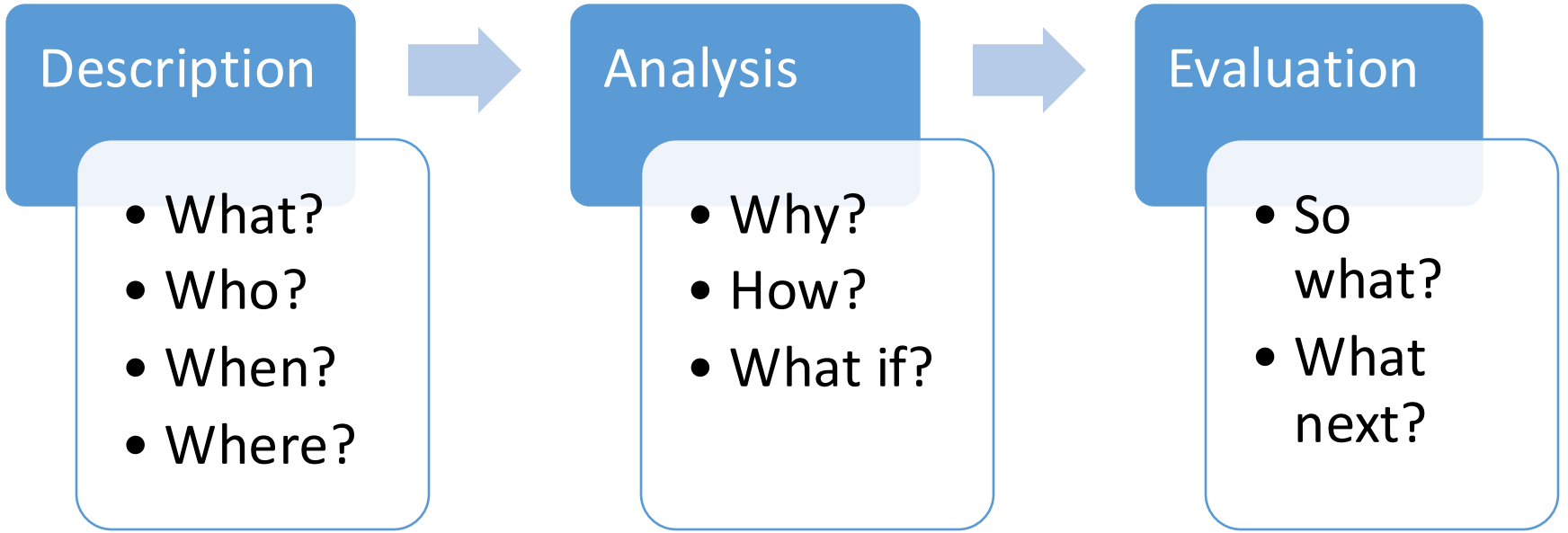
What do YOU think are the most important elements of academic writing?

- No rules just write
  - tip: your thoughts straight to paper/PC
  - Don’t hesitate
- 3 minutes on the above question



Critical thinking

- This is the foundation of academic writing.
- Critical thinking can be linked to practice.



Literature review - main objectives

- Determines known and unknown information
- Identifies new, inconsistent and gaps in knowledge
- Synthesises relevant research approaches, highlighting their strengths and weaknesses
- Specifies potential impacts on practice
- Identifies your research question

You then apply synthesis

‘…bring[s] together research to show you’ve grasped the relationship between them.’

(Williams, 2013: 131)

Williams, K. (2013) *Planning Your Dissertation*. Palgrave Macmillan.

Avoiding pitfalls - Examiners views

What do examiners ask themselves about the literature review:

1. To what extent is the review relevant to the topic?
2. Has the candidate slipped into ‘here is everything I know about topic x…’?
3. Is there evidence of critical appraisal?
4. Does the candidate make explicit links between the literature and their research?

(Murray, 2006)

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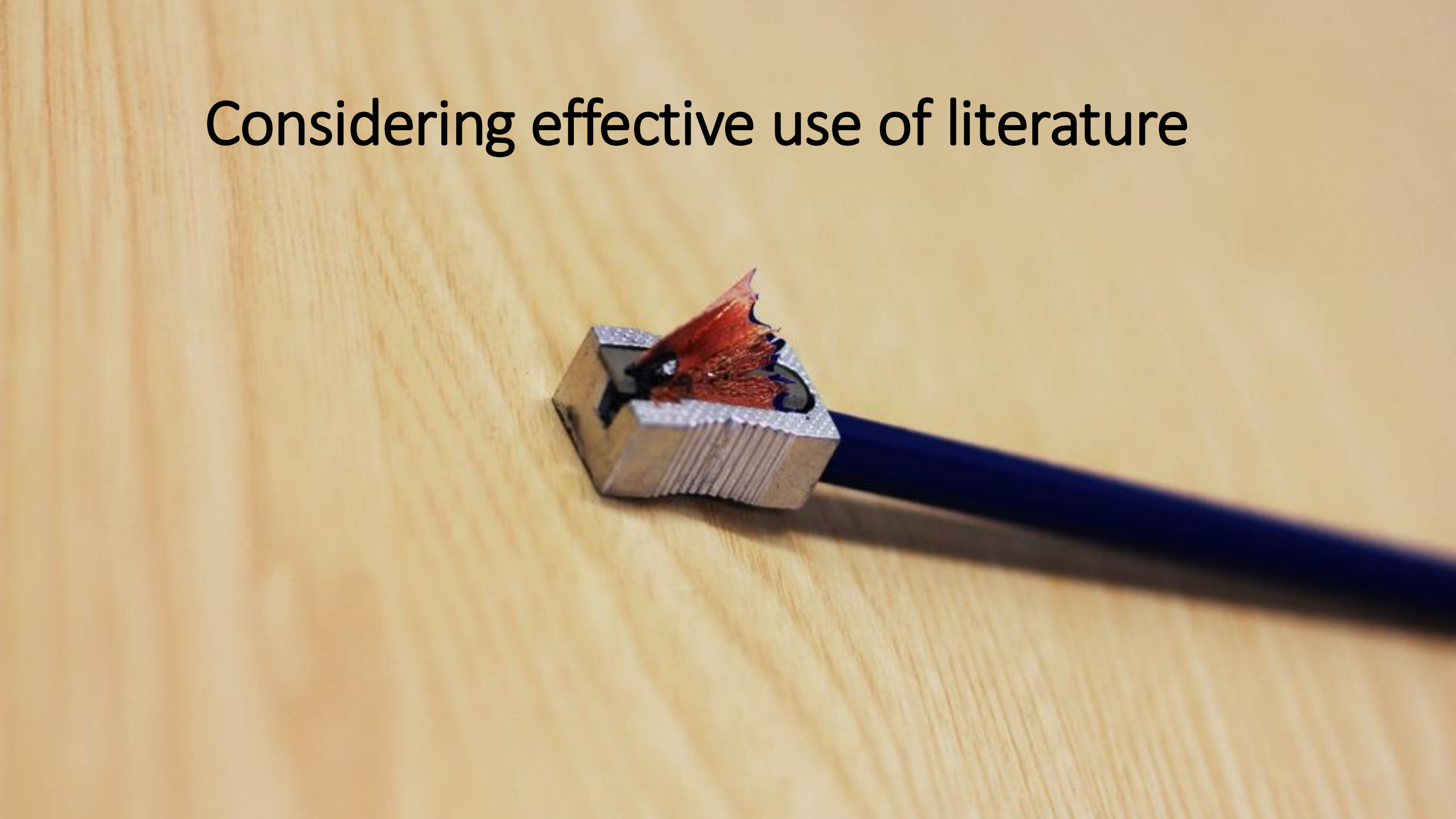
Important characteristics

1. Is there evidence of critical appraisal?
2. Does the candidate make **explicit links** between the literature and their research?

(Murray, 2006)

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Considering effective use of literature



From the perspective of writing a literature review:

1. Deciding on the literature review topic
2. Search the literature (provided in another session)
3. Being critical of the literature you find
4. Knowing what to keep or discard
5. Deciding the order of your points and ‘themes’
6. Writing your review

1. Deciding on the literature review topic

XX-XX-XX

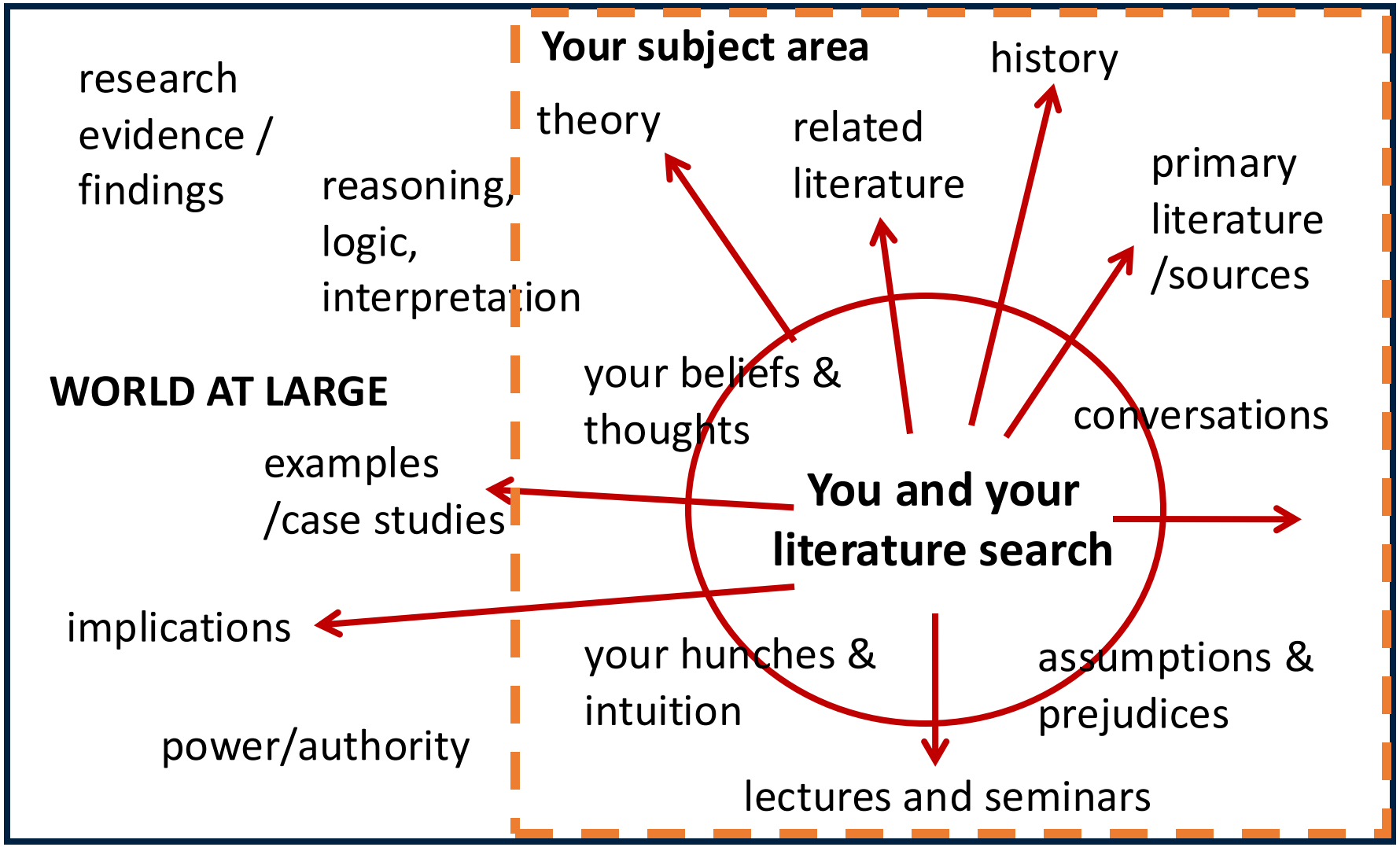
Deciding on the research topic

What more can you learn from the **assignment brief / supervisor**?

- What are your **Learning Outcomes**?
- How can you align both to meet the **marking criteria (rubric)**?
- What topics have you agreed on with your supervisor?

- Any other steps to keep focus???

Targeting your literature research



Adapted from Hilsdon (2004)

Important steps

Scoping study - you do the following:

1. **Define your topic:** Clearly state what you want to study.
2. **Search for research:** Look for existing studies and information on your topic.
3. **Choose relevant studies:** Decide which studies are most related to your topic.
4. **Organise the information:** Make a table or chart to keep track of what you find.
5. **See what's missing:** Analyse the studies to find out what's been studied and what hasn't.
6. **Write a report:** Summarise what you found and suggest what research should come next.

In simple terms, it's like exploring a new area to see what's already known and what still needs to be studied.

REMINDER: Understanding the assessment brief, creating a title OR your own research questions

Critically evaluate two key areas of cyber security and the impact it has on …

T.A.P. model: **T**opics, **A**ctions, **P**arameters

Additional parameters:

What else do you need? …Word count, font size, use of table and figures, preferred reference style? Etc …Look at your Project Handbook and marking benchmark!

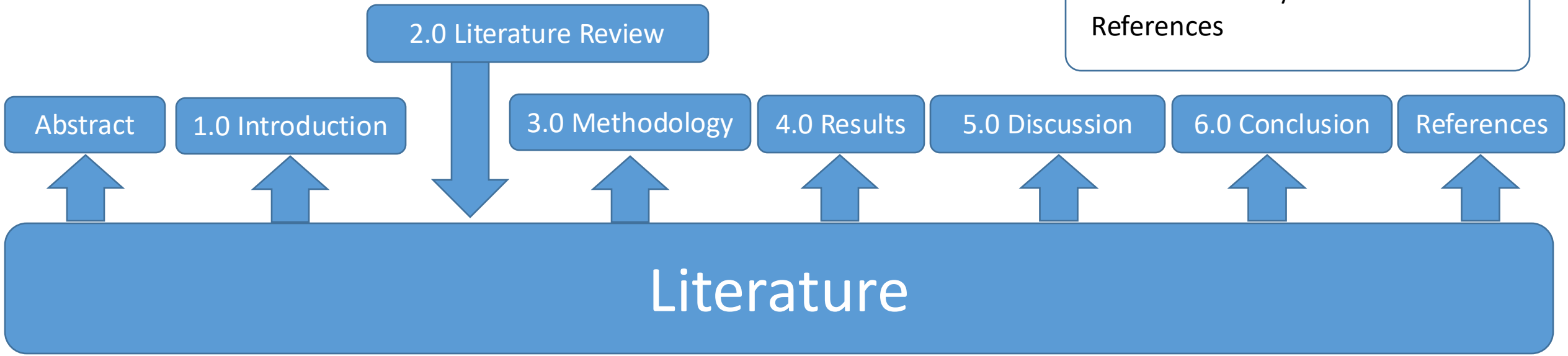
N.B. The project handbook has report styling requirements

Why would we do this literature research?

First - Literature informs the writing!

- The fundamental role of literature – it is an integral component in research and writing.
- Informs the writing and reinforces claims

Abstract
1.0 Introduction
2.0 Literature review
3.0 Methodology /procedure
4.0 Results
5.0 Discussion / critical analysis
6.0 conclusions / future work
References



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Additional benefits of using literature

- **Establishing a strong foundation** - A literature review provides a robust base of existing knowledge.
- **Identifying gaps** - It helps pinpoint gaps in existing research, paving the way for new contributions.
- **Contextualising research** - It situates your work within the broader academic context.
- **Validating research** - It demonstrates the credibility and reliability of your findings.
- **Supporting arguments** - Literature bolsters your arguments and hypotheses.
- **Learning and growth** - It enhances your understanding of the topic and promotes personal development.
- **Refining methodology** - It aids in selecting the most appropriate research methods.
- **Preventing duplication** - It avoids redundancy by ensuring you don't replicate previous work.



Differences:
Method vs Methodology

Your thoughts?

Method

1. Refers to the specific techniques or procedures used to conduct research, investigations, experiments, or any systematic activity.
2. It **describes** the **practical steps** and processes employed to collect data, carry out experiments, or achieve a particular goal.

Essentially, more focused on the practical aspects of research or any systematic work and instructions on specific tasks.

TIP:
For example, if you are conducting a survey, the method section of your research paper would describe how you selected your sample, designed your questionnaire, and collected and analysed the data.

Methodology

- A ‘broader term’ that encompasses the theoretical and philosophical framework that underlies the research process. It is **the systematic approach or strategy used to plan, design, and conduct research**.
- Includes the rationale behind the chosen research methods, the theoretical principles that guide the research, and the overall approach taken to address the research question or problem.
- Provides the intellectual foundation and justification for the choice of methods and explains why certain methods are preferred over others.
- Also considers issues such as research design, data collection, data analysis, and the interpretation of results in a more holistic manner.

2. Search the literature

(Provided in another session OR contact your Information Specialist)

2. Search the literature

Your Library 'Information Specialist' can help: https://plymouth.libguides.com/systematicreviews/types

- How to search, hints and tips:

  primo.plymouth.ac.uk

- Publications available (Including the University library).
- Recommended journals and books (see module guides).
- Conversations with tutors.

N.B. You will have a session with Kate Russell (Senior Learning and Information Specialist).

3. Being critical of the literature you find



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Critical analysis

- Constructively critical of what we read
- When critiquing texts, we must:
  - be constructive and consistent
  - consider multiple perspectives
  - ask questions of the authors

- Critical of what we write
  - claims we make and how they are substantiated
  - quality of our writing

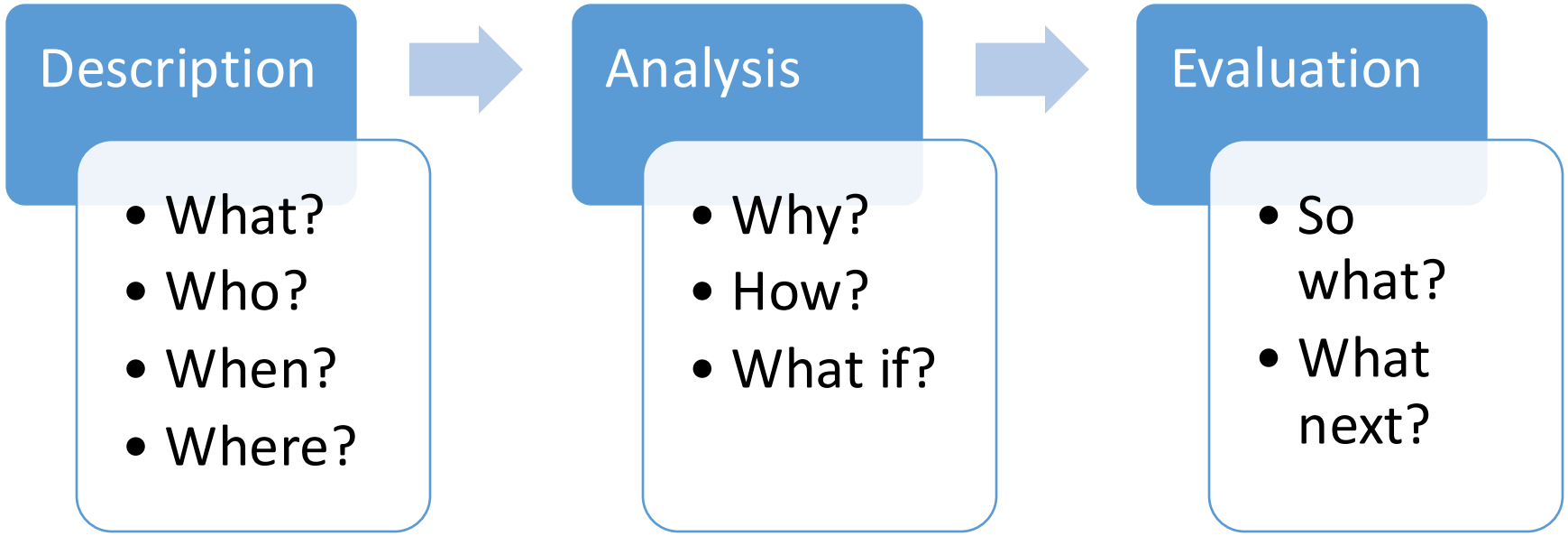
Some useful theories

- Barnett's (1977) critical being (& domains)
  - Critical reason (knowledge)
  - Critical self-reflection (self)
  - Critical action (world)

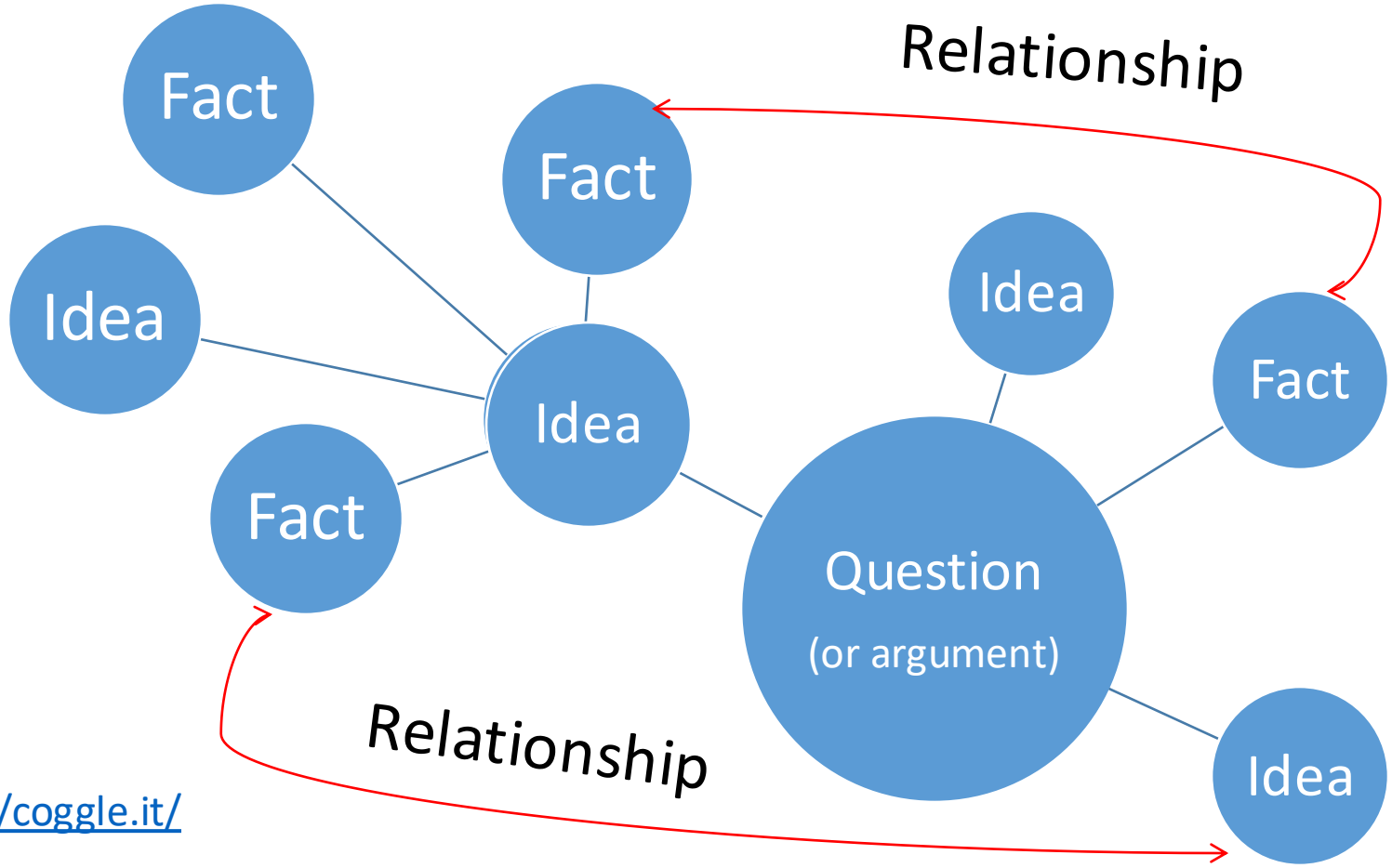
- Critical thinking happens when we do four things
  - Hunt assumptions
  - Check assumptions
  - Consider multiple perspectives
  - Take informed action (Brookfield, 2012)

Remember: Being critical

It is actually very good for asking questions of your literature.



Mind mapping



Try free option: https://coggle.it/

4. Knowing what to keep or discard

Refining your literature

4. Knowing what to keep or discard

- Linked to next step 5 (Deciding the order your ‘points’)
- Start organising your literature into a sensible order
  - Consider what really matches your chosen topic
  - What helps reinforce, but is not quite aligned
  - Things that you do not need

- Look at our online guide to reading techniques:
  - Critical synopsis – as mentioned earlier.
  - You can ‘skim’ or ‘ladder read’
  - Other times more in-depth reading is required

Suggested order to read (Not fixed)

- **Abstract:** Read the abstract to get an initial overview of the article's content.
- **Introduction:** Skim the introduction to understand the context and research question.
- **Conclusion/Discussion:** Jump to the conclusion or discussion section to grasp the key findings and implications.
- **Keywords and Figures:** Examine the keywords and any figures or diagrams in the article for additional insights.
- **Methodology:** If the article is relevant, read the methodology section to understand the research approach.
- **Results:** Explore the results section to delve deeper into the findings and data.
- **Citation and References:** Check the references cited in the article for potential sources to explore further.
- **Full Text:** Read the full article in detail if it is highly relevant to your literature review.

Abstract: How far do I need to go?

- Imagine you are writing a paper on the effects of a new drug on a specific medical condition. You come across an article with the following abstract:

Abstract: "The study presents the results of a randomized, double-blind clinical trial evaluating the efficacy of Drug X in treating patients with Condition Y. Our findings reveal a statistically significant improvement in symptoms and a higher rate of remission in the Drug X group compared to the control group. The study involved 500 participants and was conducted over a six-month period. These promising results suggest that Drug X may be a potential breakthrough in the treatment of Condition Y."

Potentially, I/we could just use the abstract!

That abstract provides clear and concise information about the study's:

- Focus
- Methodology
- Key findings
- Implications.
- Claims statistically significant improvements
- The sample size is reasonably large (500 participants).

If this information aligns with the topic and requirements of your paper, you could cite this article based on the abstract alone.

N.B. However, it's still advisable to review the full article, if relevant, to ensure the abstract accurately represents the study's methods and results.

How to report: when making broad claims

Several studies [on topic] utilise similar methods [elaborate], of 500 or greater participants (Jones, 2021; Wilson, 2019; Xi, 2023; xxxx)

Then perhaps it is reasonable to use just the abstract?

However, IF you need to critique the quality of the methods, deeper reading would be needed.

Let’s go deeper into critical reading

Critical synopsis*

1. Why am I reading this?
2. What are the authors trying to achieve in this writing?
3. What are the authors saying that is relevant to what I want to find out?
4. How convincing are the authors?
5. In conclusion, what can I do with this knowledge?

*A critical synopsis is a condensed critique of what is known.

Example coming up, deliberately focusing outside of disciplines

When was the link between smoking and cancer established?

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"It is now an established medical truth that smoking causes cancer, but this was not always known! In 1949, Richard Doll, a researcher working for the Medical Research Council, and Bradford Hill, an epidemiologist at the London School of Hygiene, began looking at lung cancer patients in London hospitals. The patients were asked about family history, diet and previous diseases. In 649 cases of lung cancer, two were non-smokers. Doll immediately gave up his own five cigarettes a day habit. Doll and Hill extended their research to Cambridge, Bristol and Leeds and, after speaking to some 5,000 people, found the same results. In 1951, the researchers wrote to 59,600 doctors and asked about their smoking habits. They kept a watch on the doctors' health and published the results in 1954 in a paper now deemed so important that the British Medical Journal reprinted the first page last June, 50 years after the original report. Doll and Hill followed up their work and, by 1956, the link was incontrovertible: more than 200 heavy smokers had died in a four-year period while the incidence among non-smokers was negligible. After the Royal College's recommendations in 1962 - restriction of advertising; higher taxation; restrictions on sales to children and on smoking in public places; information on tar and nicotine content - cigarette sales fell for the first time in a decade."

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Jha, A. (2005) 'When was the link between smoking and cancer established?', *The Guardian Newspaper*, Thursday 2nd June.

Less Suitable Sources for Science Writing:

1. **Newspapers/websites**: News articles can be a good source for general information, but they often simplify complex scientific topics and may not provide in-depth research details.
2. **Blogs and personal websites**: Information from personal blogs or websites may lack peer review and can vary in quality.
3. **Social media**: Information from social media platforms is typically not peer-reviewed and may lack credibility.
4. **Wikipedia**: While Wikipedia can be a useful starting point for research, it is not a primary source and may contain inaccuracies.
5. **Encyclopaedias**: While encyclopaedias like Britannica can provide general knowledge, they are not primary sources for scientific research.
6. **Pseudo-scientific websites**: Websites promoting pseudoscience or conspiracy theories should be avoided as they lack scientific validity.
7. **Non-academic magazines**: Popular science magazines often provide simplified versions of scientific discoveries and may not be as rigorous as peer-reviewed journals.

Thoughts on this text?

Fully-managed AI (Artificial Intelligence) Services

Recently, we can also observe a growing trend of AI capabilities being offered in the form of fully-managed AI services. Whereas the aforementioned AI API services predominantly focus on 'oneshot' functionalities (where a user sends over some input data and receives back the results of the ML model prediction for that particular data), here the offering tends to be more complex and focused, where the service seeks to supply a partial or complete business workflow. Fully-managed AI services might ingest a variety of customer data, consist of several models and steps before producing a final prediction outcome, come with dedicated UI platforms or hardware, and even interact directly with the customer's own users. These offerings typically offer a more specialised set of functionalities targeting niche industry-specific needs, examples including algorithmic hiring [65, 123], medical processes such as diagnosis and triage [70, 95, 124], and mental health self-care [62] to name but a few. Further, whereas the AI APIs generally need to be programmatically further integrated into users' own applications, fully managed services can also come as more complete products, providing dedicated mobile and web interfaces or desktop…

Lewicki *et al.* (2023) Out of Context: Investigating the Bias and Fairness Concerns of "Artificial Intelligence as a Service" In Proceedings of the 2023 CHI Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems (CHI '23). *Association for Computing Machinery*, 135, pp. 1–17. https://doi.org/10.1145/3544548.3581463

Opinion? Where is the evidence?

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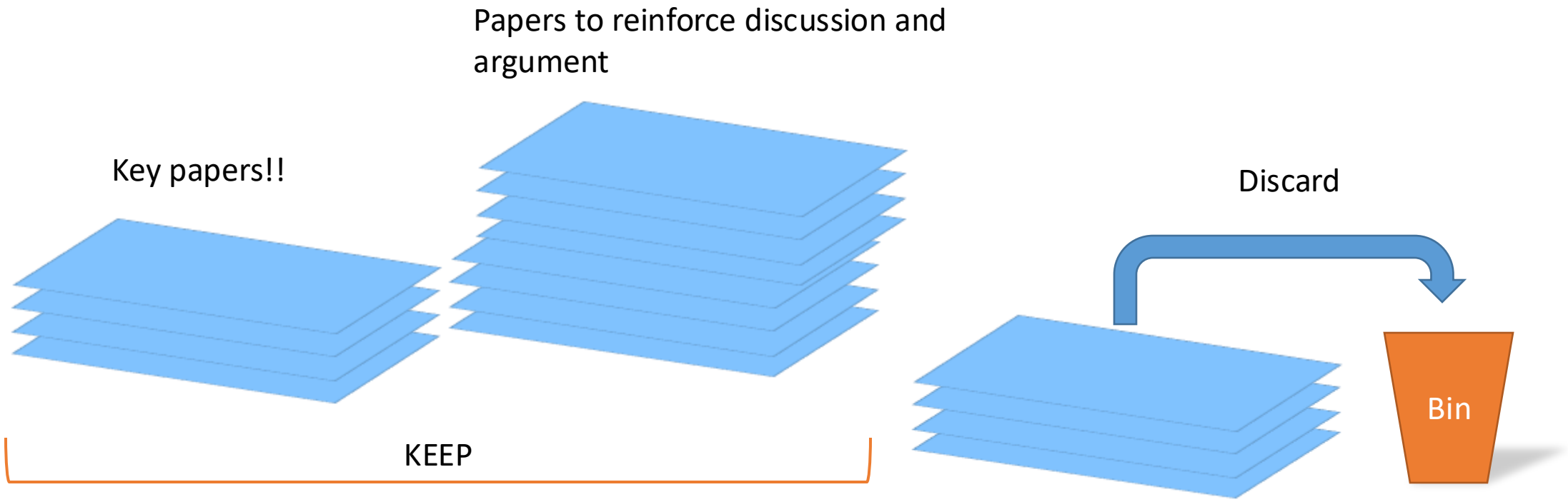
Thoughts on this text?

Business Intelligence (BI) is defined by literature and scholars in similar ways. Noble (2006) defines BI as the ability to provide the business an information advantage; business doing what it has always done, but more efficient. Singer (2001) described BI as the value proposition that helps organizations tap into decision-making information that regular reporting does not provide. Singer outlined that BI requires tools, applications, and technologies focused on enhanced decision-making and is commonly used in supply chain, sales, finance, and marketing. Negash and Gray (2008) outlined BI more comprehensively. BI is a data driven process that combines data storage and gathering with knowledge management to provide input into the business decision making process. BI enables organizations to enhance the decision making process and requires processes, skills, technology, and data. More recently, Gartner (2013) and Halpern (2015) have extended BI to be an umbrella term which includes applications, tools, infrastructure, and practices to enable access and analysis of information to optimize performance and decision-making. (Larson and Chang, p.701)

Larson, D. and Chang, V. (2016) 'A review and future direction of agile, business intelligence, analytics and data science', International journal of information management, Vol.36 (5), pp.700-710.

4. Knowing what to keep or discard

Organising your papers (books etc) into themes. Consider:



What about quality of literature?

This can be helpful in knowing what to keep and discard

Reputable sources for science writing:

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1. **Peer-Reviewed Scientific Journals:** Journals such as Nature, Science, The Lancet, and many others publish research articles that have undergone rigorous peer review.
2. **Academic books:** Scholarly books written by experts in the field are valuable sources for in-depth information, although not always up to date.
3. **Government publications:** Reports and studies from UK government agencies like the National Health Service (NHS) or Public Health England are reliable sources.
4. **University websites:** Academic institutions often publish research papers, reports, and other academic materials on their websites (peer-reviewed preferred).
5. **Databases:** Scientific databases like PubMed, Scopus, and Web of Science provide access to a wide range of peer-reviewed articles and papers.
6. **Research conferences:** Proceedings from reputable scientific conferences often contain valuable research findings.
7. **Research institutions:** Websites of scientific research institutions and laboratories can provide up-to-date information.

5. Deciding the order of your ‘points’

Title: A typical example of academic writing

Introduction

- First sentence relates to title and has a 'hook' to keep reader interested.
- Background
- Say what points will be discussed.
- Predominantly future tense. E.g. 'The following **will** be discussed…'

Discussion

- Discuss those points in the same order…
- **Point 1** – Describe, analyse & evaluate.
- **Point 2** – Describe, analyse & evaluate.
- **Cont.** – Describe, analyse & evaluate.
- Ensure logical flow of ideas

Conclusions

- Are a summary of the evaluations!
- Don't add anything new.
- Write mainly in past tense. E.g. 'It **was** found'.

Remember, these are your points of argument

5. Deciding the order of your ‘points’



1. Think about how this will all flow in your text
2. How will any introduced themes* relate to my main points
3. Will others be able to follow your writing?

*A **theme** is a central idea or conceptual focus that connects and organises the key points of a piece of writing. It is not itself an argument, but it shapes how arguments are framed, interpreted, and related to one another. Scientific writing is should be clear, concise and focused, so use themes carefully.

6. Writing your review

Literature review (overview)

2. Literature review

- **Purpose**: Reviews existing research and literature relevant to the research topic, identifying gaps and justifying the need for the study.
- **Structure**:
  - **Introduction**: Introduces the scope and purpose of the literature review.
  - **Thematic or chronological organisation**: Organises the literature by themes, trends, or chronology.
  - **Critical analysis**: Summarises, analyses, and critiques previous studies, theories, and findings.
  - **Identification of gaps**: Highlights gaps in the existing research that the current study aims to address.
  - **Conclusion**: Summarises the key findings from the literature and sets up the research questions or hypotheses.

TIP: your evidence can be pointing or hinting towards those 'gaps'. Often subtitle but builds as the review continues

Title: Literature review on [topic]…

Introduction

- What will be reviewed
- Basically, introduce scope and purpose

Literature review section

- Critical appraisal of relevant literature (main points and themes)
- Be critical of quality of texts
- Compare and contrast
  - Remember this is showing what is available, but also a subtle critique of research, not full discussion.
- 'Hints' at the gaps in knowledge (emerging themes)

Conclusions

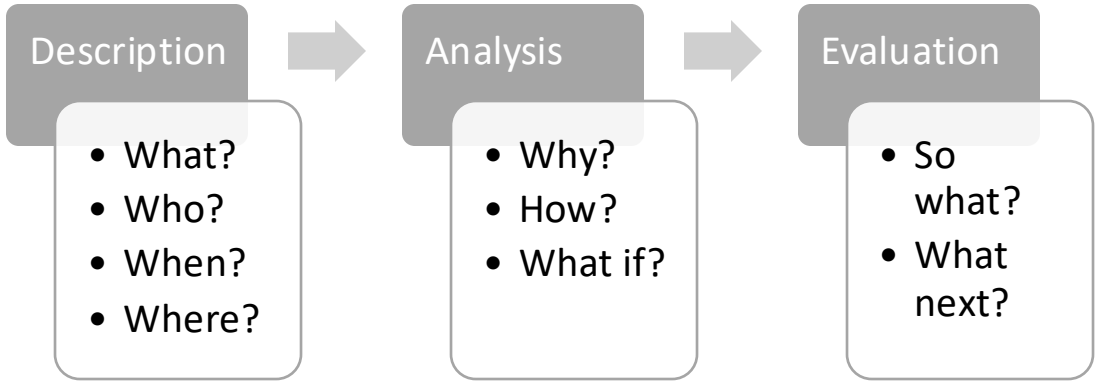
Summary of your evaluations above

References

- Only the ones used in your writing

The critical thinking model can be used

- Structurally useful for literature reviews (Supported with references throughout)



Describe, Analyse and Evaluate

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Looking at agile software development processes (ASDP) for any software company, it is particularly important to consider how iterative cycles, stakeholder feedback, and cross-functional collaboration contribute to overall project success (Peters, 2016). According to Matthew (2015), this should always be aligned with the company's strategic goals and user requirements to ensure relevance and adaptability. Peters (2016) gives effective approaches for usability improvements…

However, looking first at implementation challenges, there are concerns that poor ASDP practices can lead to fragmented communication, scope creep, and reduced product quality (Harrison, 2016). Therefore, it is essential to embed clear protocols and team roles to mitigate these risks. Certainly, ASDPs need proper implementation to ensure consistency and accountability, as also suggested by Adams (2006), who emphasises the importance of agile coaching and retrospectives. Although one major drawback of this approach is that it can be resource-intensive and difficult to scale across large organisations (Peters, 2016). Therefore, in order to ensure that the outcome is favourable, a new approach was introduced to counteract these issues. Importantly, Brian (2016) provides a solution whereby ASDPs are able to integrate hybrid models, combining agile with traditional project management frameworks. In contrast, others were not able to implement a new structure due to the constraints of legacy systems and rigid organisational hierarchies, as Jacobs (2017) highlights in his study of enterprise-level transitions…

Having considered all the important issues associated with ASDP in modern software environments, there is clear evidence that more needs to be done to standardise agile practices and tailor them to specific organisational contexts, particularly in sectors with strict compliance requirements. Making these changes would not only improve software usability, but also enhance team morale, reduce delivery times, and increase stakeholder satisfaction. Therefore, it is recommended…

PLEASE NOTE: if you use any acronyms, make sure they are explained within the text!

Discussion vs Literature review: Key differences

Very important!

Discussion vs Literature review: Key differences

Purpose:

Discussion interprets your own findings; literature review summarises existing knowledge.

Voice:

Discussion is analytical and fully argumentative; literature review is typically more descriptive (but also critically evaluative).

Focus:

Discussion looks inward to what your results mean; literature review looks outward to what others have said.

Contribution:

Discussion explains how your study fills them; literature review identifies gaps.

Structure:

Discussion links your data back to theory and implications; literature review groups themes from prior research.

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Different approaches in writing

Literature Review style (descriptive, summarising others, yet critically evaluative):

Research consistently shows that urban green spaces play a significant role in improving air quality and supporting biodiversity. **For instance, Tzoulas *et al.* (2007) highlight** that well-designed green infrastructure can mitigate pollution and enhance ecological resilience. **Similarly, Gill *et al.* (2007) argue** that increasing vegetation cover helps cities adapt to climate-related temperature rises by providing natural cooling. **However, comparatively** there are limited studies on… (references).

Yours

Discussion style (interpreting *your* findings, and others, full critical thinking):

In this research, neighbourhoods with newly planted mixed species tree corridors showed a clear reduction in roadside particulate matter **(Table 1). This supports Tzoulas *et al.*'s (2007)** view that green infrastructure helps mitigate pollution, and it suggests that even small interventions can deliver quick local benefits. **In contrast to Gill *et al.*'s (2007)** emphasis on temperature regulation, our findings point to air quality as the most immediate gain in dense residential areas **(Figure 2)**. **However, Figure 2** also indicates that it is still unclear how far these reductions can be attributed to the tree corridors alone. Therefore, it is...

How to use the literature to your advantage?

If you were referring to this text alone from a journal:

"Data science plays a pivotal role in enhancing business analytics by providing valuable insights from vast datasets. It has been **widely claimed** that the application of data science techniques can lead to significant improvements in decision-making and performance in various industries [2]. **For instance**, predictive modelling and machine learning algorithms [3] have been heralded as tools that can revolutionise customer targeting and retention strategies, ultimately increasing profitability [4,5]."

How to report on the literature: example

“While the article by [Author surname, (year)] emphasises the transformative potential of data science in business analytics, it also suggests a positive impact of predictive modelling and machine learning on customer targeting and profitability. However, the study provides limited empirical evidence or specific case studies to support these assertions. It could therefore be argued that…“

Tip: The absence of concrete examples or quantitative data makes it challenging to fully evaluate the actual effectiveness of these techniques in real-world business scenarios.

Referencing

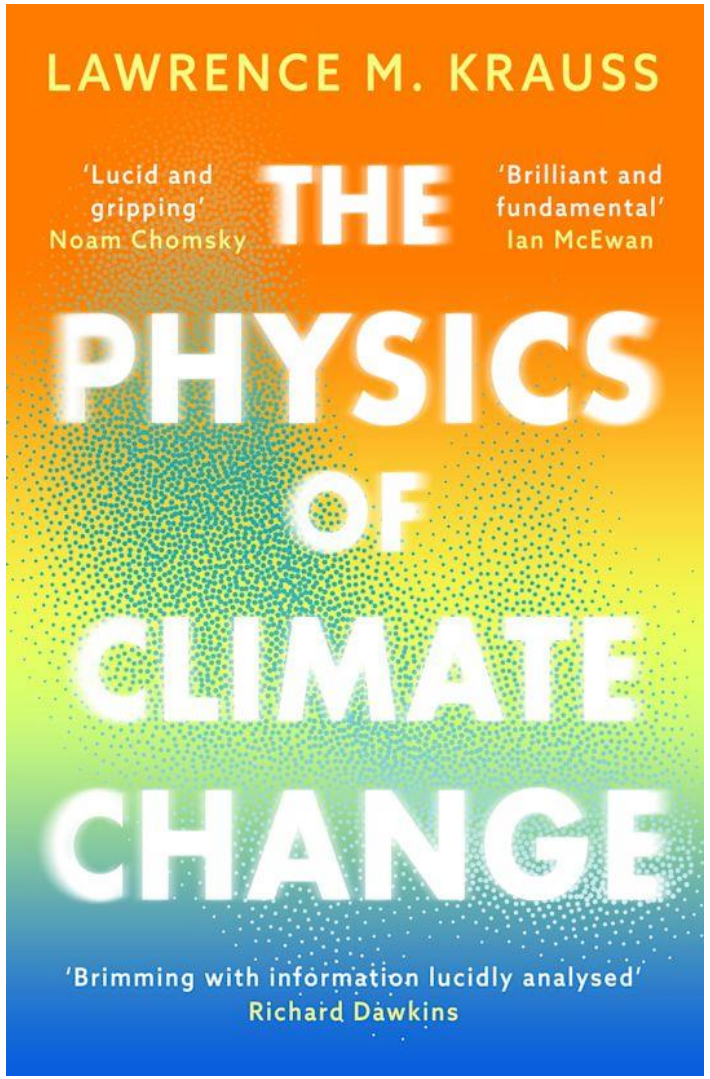
What does that look like?

How to reference

- Cite Them Right (book and also online) http://www.citethemrightonline.com.plymouth.idm.oclc.org/
- Off campus
  - This link includes university authentication (bookmark for future reference)
- Look up a book, a webpage, and a journal article



How would you create a reference from this?



Information on publisher's page:

- **Printed book**
- **Format**: paperback
- **Publisher:** Bloomsbury Publishing
- **Published:** 4 Jan 2024
- **Edition**: 1st
- **Pages**: 208
- **Weight:** 150g
- **ISBN:** 9781837933532

https://www.bloomsbury.com/uk/physics-of-climate-change-9781837933532/

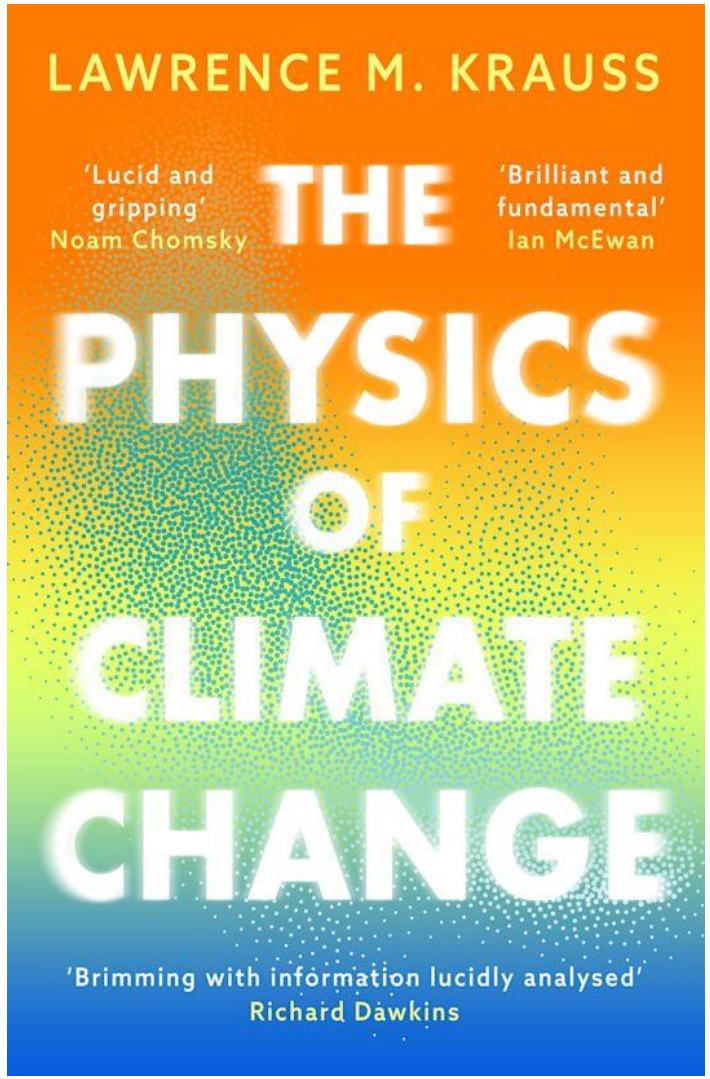
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Answer coming up

Answer



Information on publisher's page:

- **Printed book**
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- **Publisher:** Bloomsbury Publishing
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This is not always available.

- ~~**Pages**: 208~~
- ~~**Weight:** 150g~~
- ~~**ISBN:** 9781837933532~~

~~https://www.bloomsbury.com/uk/physics-of-climate-change-9781837933532/~~

Answer

Krauss, L.M. (2024) *The physics of climate change*. 1st Edn. Bloomsbury Publishing.

Example of using multiple references

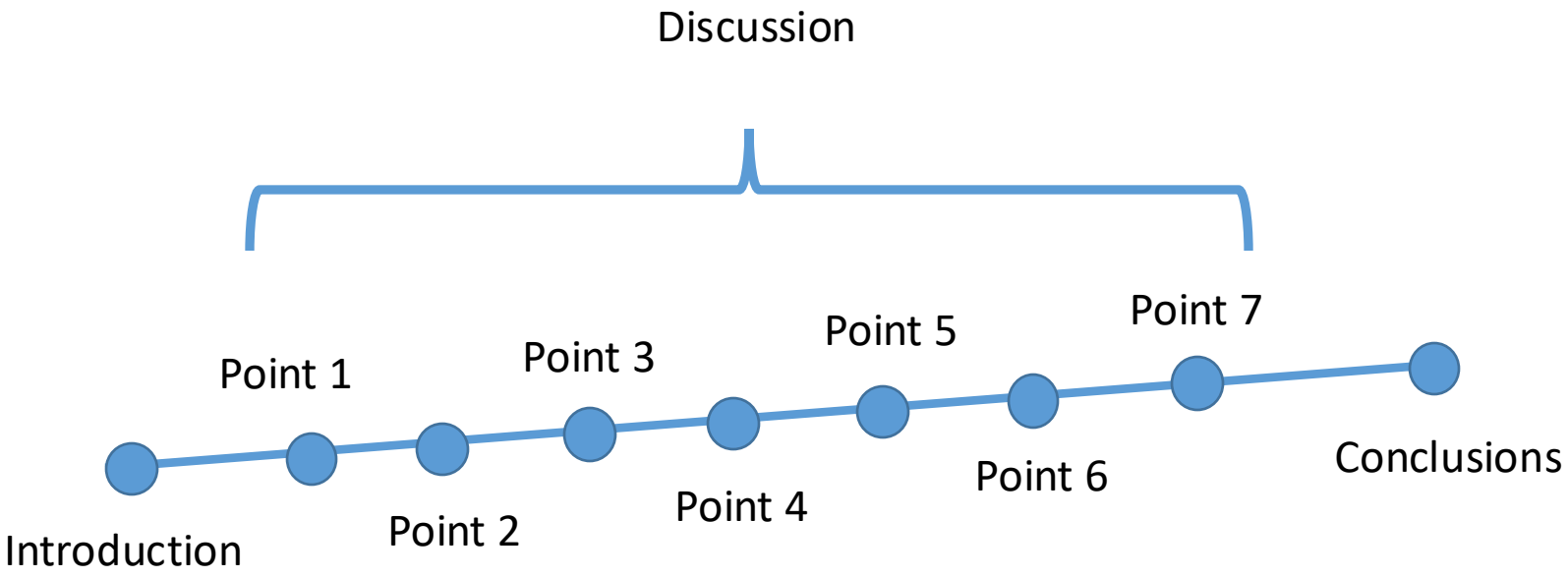
'…Let's take a closer look at the popular Big Data application known as sentiment analysis (Schweidel and Moe, 2014), which is based on opinions expressed online. How representative are these opinions? Social media should be thought of as the world's largest focus group, and be analyzed as such. For example, if 20 people are complaining loudly about some feature of a product on a review site, the company should treat this as an insight and investigate further. The company cannot infer, for example, the fraction of all targeted customers who have this complaint, which would require a more rigorous sampling plan. The company does not know if those complaining are customers, or if they are, in reality, employees at a competitor sabotaging the brand (Hu *et al.*, 2011, 2012; Chevalier and Mayzlin, 2006; Mayzlin *et al.*, 2014; Anderson and Simester, 2014; Li and Hitt, 2008; Anderson and Magruder, 2012). Nor can the company infer the effect of the complaints on sales…'

Hofacker, Malthouse, and Sultan (2016, p.93)

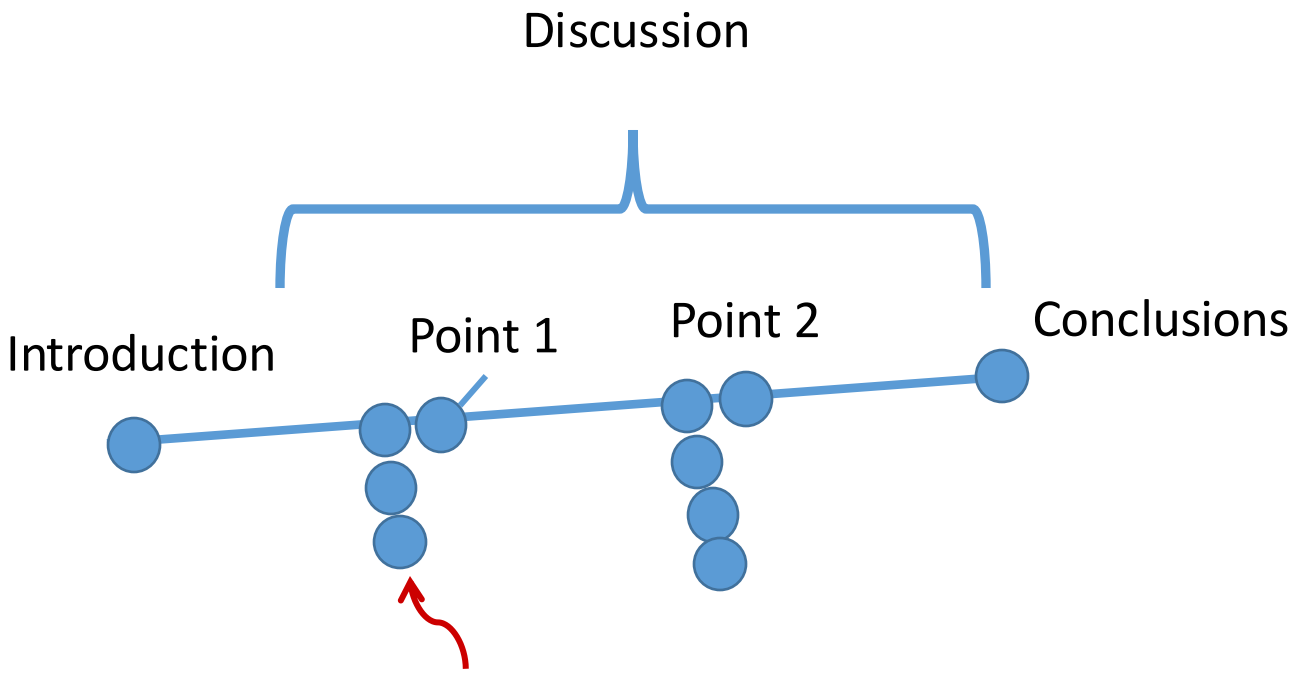
Hofacker, C. F., Malthouse, E. C. and Sultan, F. (2016) 'Big Data and consumer behavior: imminent opportunities', *Journal of Consumer Marketing,* 33(2), pp. 89-97.

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Wrote too many points?
How would you rectify this…?



You can keep your references …and keep your focus!



Say what it is you are aware of… (Ref + Ref + Ref)
HOWEVER, focusing on…point 1 and its importance...

Recommendations (homework)

1. Choose the review question.
2. Formulate your own question that specifically describes what you would like to know about your chosen topic.
3. Use Primo and Google Scholar to search for and locate journals that include your topic's information.
4. Find articles, read the abstracts and skim the articles to determine if they correspond well to your topic AND question.
5. Read your articles and begin to sort and classify them according to their findings.
6. Organise your articles by sorting and classifying their findings in a meaningful way, always considering your original topic and question.
7. Write an outline for your review.
8. Write the review and submit as a draft.
9. Review feedback on your draft, edit and adjust your review prior to resubmission. (Royal Literary Writing Fellow, Writing Café and Supervisors)

Summing up

- Use different techniques to be critical of texts
  - You can give opinions in texts, just ensure you reference the text afterwards
- Employ critical thinking in writing construction
  - Describe, analyse, evaluate
- Reference to support your arguments
  - Opinion alone appears less trustworthy

Keep writing

- Write regularly, 15-30 mins a day, to maintain momentum
- Avoid over-elaborate writing, be concise and to the point; being aware of linking phrases and flow
- Proofread aloud and carefully to ensure proper language use and readability
- Talk about your ideas and writing as much as you can with others
- Read academic texts to see how they ‘sound’, follow the principles of their good practice

Feedback on this workshop 2026-7

tell us what you think...

Questions?

